They crossed the valley of Catamarca: A study of narrative space in novel openings

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Problem Description and State of Research[1]

Novel openings' similarities and differences raise literary-historical questions. With our contribution, we aim to advance that research by means of digital text annotation and spatiality analysis of the openings of a selection of nineteenth- and twentieth-century novels in German and Spanish. The background of our research is the ongoing interdisciplinary project CANSpiN: *Computational Approaches to Narrative Space in 19th and 20th Century Novels*, which is based at the University of Rostock in Germany.

So far, Literary Studies research on the openings of novels is mostly fragmented into author-related studies, has brought together only a few general studies and reviews (Adamo 2000, Said 1975) and is essentially narratological (Bendheim 2017: 25, Krings 2004: 163, Neumann 1996: 21, Nuttall 1992). The literary-historical theses thus produced link narrative techniques at the opening of novels with the amount and functions of narrated space (Hirdt 1974: 433, Maier 1965: 150). What these approaches have not taken into account, however, is the *spatiality* of the novel, i.e. the *space-referential expressions* a text offers. These are in the context of Computational Literary Studies the central means of capturing space (Schumacher 2023). Analyzing that textual property promises on the one hand, supplementing existing research results from Literary Studies. For example, the theses that a *classical exposition* is more spatial than a *modern* opening *in medias res* should be examined from the point of view of the spatiality of texts, as well (Krings 2004: 169, Neumann 1996: 29). On the other hand, completely unexpected patterns could be discovered and examined.

Space-referential Expressions in Novels

For annotating space-referential expressions we developed the annotation guideline CANSpiN.CS1 (Henny-Krahmer et al. 2024, 2025a). In an epistemological understanding of space, we distinguish place, movement, dimensioning, direction, and positioning (see Fig. 1).

1. They [went]$_{\text{Movement-Subject}}$ [into]$_{\text{Direction}}$ the [garden]$_{\text{Place-Container}}$ and stood in [front]$_{\text{Positioning}}$ of the [big]$_{\text{Dimensioning-Size}}$ tree, when an apple [fell]$_{\text{Movement-Object}}$ [down]$_{\text{Direction-}}$
2. That night he dreamed of [Paris]$_{\text{Place-Container}}$ and now thought about how he would [look]$_{\text{Movement-Light}}$ [out]$_{\text{Direction}}$ of the [hotel]$_{\text{Place-Container}}$ [window]$_{\text{Place-Object}}$ next week.

Figure 1: Example annotations.

With the help of its spatial vocabulary, we capture both: the spatiality of the text and the narrated world.

Corpus Description

We see our contribution as a preliminary to full-scale distant reading studies. To clarify whether patterns in the spatial vocabulary of novel openings can be used to categorize these is a prerequisite for such studies. For our analysis we chose eight introductory chapters from German, Spanish, and Latin American texts of the nineteenth and twentieth century originating from four corpora of the CANSpiN project (two from each corpus, see Fig. 2).

Corpus	Text ID	Author	Title	Language	Reference Year
DEU19	DEU19_030	Gustav Freytag	Die verlorene Handschrift	German	1864
DEU19	DEU19_001	Ernst Adolf Willkomm	Weisse Sclaven oder die Leiden des Volkes	German	1845
DEU20	DEU20_002	Heinrich Böll	Ansichten eines Clowns	German	1963
DEU20	DEU20_021	Uwe Johnson	Zwei Ansichten	German	1965
SPA19	SPA19_001	Enrique Gil y Carrasco	El Señor de Bembibre	Spanish	1844
SPA19	SPA19_008	Juan de Dios Mora	Los templarios	Spanish	1856
LAT19	LAT19_004	Roberto Payró	El falso Inca	Spanish (Argentina)	1905
LAT19	LAT19_041	Juana Manuela Gorriti	El pozo del Yocci	Spanish (Argentina)	1876

Figure 2: Overview of the selected texts for the study of novel openings.

Analysis

Analyzing openings of novels comes with unsolved problems concerning the question which text to select as *opening* (Bendheim 2017, Retsch 2000, Ruta 2004: 111–112). In our study, only the first chapter of the novel is considered as its opening, since it is the smallest logical and semantic unit which contains enough textual material for an analysis.

Our main interest is to identify possible correlations between different types of novel openings and spatial vocabulary: Do certain novel beginnings use particularly much or little spatial vocabulary and do they favour certain categories of spatiality?

For these questions, we analyze the novels' openings qualitatively by distinguishing grades of *expositionality* (the degree of basic information about place, time, and characters, see Krings 2004: 168–169), the difference between *ab ovo* and *in medias res* beginnings (which goes back to Horace and asks if the events told in the first chapter are part of the backstory or the main story (*plot*), see Retsch 2000: 14), and by describing the entrance and first event of each novel (see Fig. 3). The data, the code as well as explanations on the categorization of the novel beginnings can be found in our Github Repository (Henny-Krahmer et al. 2025b).

Text ID	Gram-matical person	Narrator	Discourse	Story	General entrance description	First character event (sentence no. , token no.)
DEU19_030	3rd	hetero-diegetic	high expo-sitionality	in medias res	The opening is a spatial description of a nightly scene in a forest by moonlight. The narrator addresses the moon as a person and the narrators descriptions of the scene kind of moves through the landscape until arriving at the professors house, where characters act and are introduced.	professor looks at a manuscript (37/315, 955/7179)
DEU19_001	3rd	hetero-diegetic	high expo-sitionality	in medias res	The chapter opens with a spatial description of the area of the Niederlausitz and especially of the area of the Haide, including mentions of cities, settlements, rivers, forests and a short summarizing description of the inhabitants' life without referring to individual characters. After this description the movement of a horse-drawn carriage in the year 1832 is told, introducing the characters travelling with the carriage, shortly followed by the arrival of the carriage at a tavern.	a man steers a horse-drawn carriage (13/206, 430/5491)
DEU20_002	1st	homo-diegetic	medium expo-sitionality	in medias res	The chapter begins immediately with the arrival of the protagonist in Bonn. After that, the homodiegetic narrator describes his routines in the city and events of the past five years, introducing places and other characters.	arrival in Bonn (1/86, 10/2689)
DEU20_021	3rd	hetero-diegetic	medium expo-sitionality	in medias res	The chapter immediatly starts with the act of buying a car by Mr. B.. After that, preceding events are told which lead to the purchase. The first chapter tells preceding events to a central event of the plot: the theft of the car during a stay in West-Berlin in August 1961, but altogether the plot extends further into the past, beginning with the first contact between B. and D.	Mr. B. buys a car (1/43, 13/744)
SPA19_001	3rd	hetero-diegetic	high expo-sitionality	in medias res	The plot starts immediately by three knights coming from a market on horseback. They talk about important characters in the plot and their sympathies for them until they arrive in the village of Arganza.	travel of three knights (18/1842, 1/54)
SPA19_008	3rd	hetero-diegetic	medium expo-sitionality	in medias res	The novel starts with spatial descriptions of a nocturnal scenery of properties of the Knights Templar with a castle and a church. This also includes a ruined tower, which is first described from the outside and then from the inside, where the main character is introduced. After this introduction, his journey into the tower's cellar is told and how he finds a prisoner down there.	Inhabitant of the tower walks around inside (401/4291, 12/158)
LAT19_004	3rd	hetero-diegetic	medium expo-sitionality	in medias res	In the year 1556, two travellers - an Andalusian man named Pedro Chamjo and a woman with indigenous and Spanish features named Carmen - cross the valley of Catamarca at dusk. Tired, they decide to camp under a tree. As they prepare a simple meal, they talk in hushed tones about a mysterious plan involving the governor and the possibility of restoring an indigenous power, perhaps an 'Inca' with many subjects. The next morning, a Spanish soldier surprises Pedro, calls his name and points an arquebus at him, revealing that they were being watched. The novel opens directly with the first events involving the two characters; however, the reader also gets basic information about the place and time of the story in the first chapter.	travel of indigenous man and women through valley of Catamarca (17/1128, 1/37)
LAT19_041	3rd	hetero-diegetic	high expo-sitionality	ab ovo	The story is set in 1814, in the midst of the wars for South American independence. As the continent struggles to free itself from Spanish rule, it depicts the profound social and familial conflict that the revolution has provoked: young men embrace the liberating cause, while many parents loyal to Spain reject them, fleeing with their possessions or following the royalist armies. In this context, a column of the royalist army retreats through the ravine of León, in Jujuy. They advance under constant fire from patriot guerrillas hiding on the heights. Finally, they cross the desolate pass of Abra de Tumbaya, leaving the fertile Jujuy valley behind them.	no character-related event in the first chapter (n.a./27, n.a./1011)

Figure 3: Analysis of expositionality and story entrances of novel openings.

Based on this terminology, we can ask whether a highly expositional novel opening is more spatial overall and whether it contains more places than a little expositional opening, which could primarily contain movements, whether in medias res and ob ovo openings correlate with certain degrees of expositionality, and whether the spatial vocabulary before and after the first event differs in terms of quantity and categories used.

Fig. 4 shows the annotation amounts of space-referential expressions inside the initial chapters of the novels in percentage of all tokens of the chapters. These results do not confirm that texts with a high expositionality (DEU19_030, DEU19_001, SPA19_001, LAT19_041) are in general particularly spatial or contain significantly more places than less expositional chapters, as two of these (DEU19_030 and SPA19_001) are rather in the middle range in terms of the proportion of spatial vocabulary and only two (DEU19_001 and LAT19_041) are above average. In addition, texts with medium expositionality can also use a high amount of spatial vocabulary (DEU20_021).

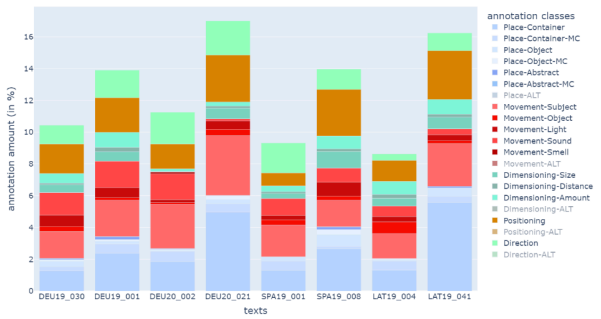

Figure 4: CS1 annotation amounts inside the initial chapters (in percentage of the total token amount of the respective chapter).

The difference between ab ovo and in medias res beginnings is shown by the fact that a larger amount of spatial vocabulary is used in the novel with an ab ovo beginning (LAT19_041). On the other hand, this is not the novel with the largest quantity of spatial vocabulary, which is why no clear indication of a connection can be proven here. For this, larger amounts of text would have to be included.

The relevance of the question of the connection between spatial vocabulary and the first events for the beginnings of novels can be seen in the example of the DEU19_030 text. With the first event, the amount of spatial vocabulary suddenly decreases in the course of the text and certain categories (positionings and places) have a significantly lower proportion in the part of the chapter following the event (see Fig. 5).

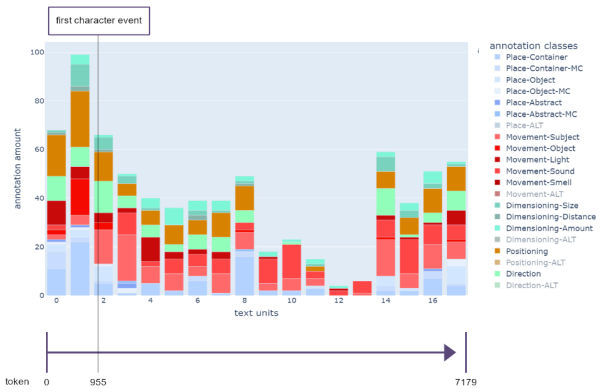

Figure 5: CS1 annotation distribution in DEU19_030 (in text units of 400 token) and position of the first character-related event in the course of the chapter.

Conclusions and Next Steps

After these exemplary analyses of the first annotation data, it is already clear that for some novels, the space-referential expressions are related to the category of novel opening, but not in all the cases. To be able to make more general statements that go beyond the individual text, more data is required. Possible next steps could therefore include LLMs for automatic annotation of larger amounts of text with the categories of space-referential expressions described here.

Notes

1. Contributor Roles: Nils Kellner (Conceptualization, Data curation, Writing – original draft, Writing – review & editing), Marc Lemke (Conceptualization, Data curation, Software, Visualization, Writing – original draft, Writing – review & editing), Ulrike Henny-Krahmer (Conceptualization, Data curation, Project administration, Writing – original draft, Writing – review & editing), Julián Carlos Spinelli (Data curation, Writing – original draft), Erik Renz (Data curation), Anika Piotraschke (Data curation).

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